



▲ MESA VERDE

The Ancestral Puebloans inhabited southwest North America between c. 100 CE and c. 1600. They moved from a hunter-gatherer lifestyle to farming when they began to create permanent settlements. In the mountainous terrain of the region they constructed great villages in the shelter of overhanging cliffs. The biggest example is the Cliff Palace at Mesa Verde in Colorado, built between 1150 and 1300 using materials such as sandstone and mortar.

Cultures of North America

The first human inhabitants of North America were present at least 23,000 to 21,000 years ago according to archeological evidence. For thousands of years, a rich mix of civilizations and cultures used the varied landscape of North America for hunting, fishing, and farming.

EVERYDAY LIFE

Maize was first grown in the dry land of the southwest around 4,000 years ago, before spreading into the north. Maize grew quickly and was easy to harvest, making it a vital food for early civilizations on the North American continent.



There are conflicting theories about the first humans in North America, and where they came from. Indigenous people have their own beliefs about how they arrived on the continent. The earliest tribes to arrive were hunters and gatherers, some of them nomadic, who kept on moving to follow migrating herds of animals.

Over time, advanced cultures began to develop, whose people grew a variety of crops, built homes, and handcrafted tools and other artifacts. From around 500 BCE, the Adena people of the Eastern Woodlands,

an area that stretched from the Atlantic Ocean to the Great Plains, farmed the land and built large earth mounds that served as ceremonial sites. A few centuries later, the Hopewell people set up villages and made pottery in the same region. By 800 CE, the Ancestral Puebloans had built large homes from earth and stone in the southwest. Gradually, these civilizations expanded and spread across the continent. By the late 1400s, North America was home to almost 60 million Indigenous people.